A Legend of the Northland

The big idea

Phoebe Cary's poem is a **ballad**, a story told in verse, from the cold Northland (**Lapland**), where days are short and nights long. **Saint Peter** visits a selfish woman and asks for a cake. Her greed is punished: she is turned into a **woodpecker** that must bore into hard wood for its food.

BALLAD

A **ballad** is a narrative poem, often a folk tale, in short stanzas (usually quatrains) with a simple rhyme scheme and a moral. This poem is written in **quatrains** (four-line stanzas) rhyming **ABCB**.

Summary

1. In Lapland, the poet heard a legend that children there are told.
2. **Saint Peter**, tired and hungry, came to the cottage of a little woman who was **baking cakes** by the fire. He had fasted all day and asked her for one cake.
3. She made a **very small cake**, but as it baked it looked **too large** to give away. She made a smaller one, then a still smaller one, and each time it seemed too big to give.
4. Finally she said, "My cakes that seem too small when I eat of them myself are yet too large to give away" and put them on the shelf.
5. Saint Peter was angry. He said she was **too selfish to dwell in human form** and would have to build her nest and get her scanty food by **boring and boring and boring** all day in **hard, dry wood**.
6. She went up through the chimney, never speaking a word, and came out of the top a **woodpecker**. She had a **scarlet cap on her head**, but every other

part of her was burned **black as coal** in the flame.

7. Every country schoolboy has seen her in the woods, boring upon the trees for food.

Characters

- **The woman**: greedy, selfish, mean; she had food enough but could not share.
- **Saint Peter**: a holy man who tests her kindness and punishes her selfishness.

Poetic devices

Device	Example
Ballad form	narrative, quatrains, ABCB
Simile	"black as coal"
Repetition	"boring and boring and boring"
Alliteration	"**b**oring and **b**oring and **b**oring"
Imagery	scarlet cap, coal-black body, long nights of the Northland

THE WOODPECKER'S LOOK

Red (scarlet) cap = the woman's cap. **Coal-black body** = burnt by the chimney fire.

Themes and message

- **Greed is punished**; generosity is a virtue.
- **Share with the needy**: giving even a little is better than nothing.
- A folk explanation of why the woodpecker looks as it does.

SHE DID NOT REFUSE AT ONCE

The woman agreed to give a cake but kept making smaller ones, and still found them too large to give. Her greed grew with each attempt.

LIKELY QUESTIONS

Why was Saint Peter angry? How was the woman punished? What does the poem teach? Is this a ballad? Give reasons.

Quick recap

- Lapland legend; Saint Peter asks a woman for one cake.
- Smaller and smaller cakes, still "too large to give away".
- Turned into a woodpecker: red cap, black body, boring wood for food.

Practice questions

1. Where is the legend set?
   (a) Iceland (b) Lapland (c) Norway's coast (d) Greenland
2. What was the woman doing when Saint Peter came?
   (a) Spinning wool (b) Washing clothes (c) Baking cakes (d) Feeding birds
3. Why did the woman not give any cake to Saint Peter?
   (a) She had no flour left (b) Each cake looked too large to give away (c) She did not recognise him (d) He refused to wait
4. What was the woman turned into?
   (a) A crow (b) A sparrow (c) A blackbird (d) A woodpecker
5. Why was the woodpecker coal-black?
   (a) It was born that way (b) It was burnt while going up the chimney (c) It lived in a coal mine (d) Saint Peter painted it
6. The rhyme scheme of the ballad is
   (a) AABB (b) ABAB (c) ABCB (d) ABAAB
7. Why is "A Legend of the Northland" called a ballad? Give three reasons.
8. What lesson does the poem teach? Do you think the woman's punishment was fair?

Answers: 1. b 2. c 3. b 4. d 5. b 6. c 7. see notes 8. see notes